

The Learning Portal

Turning 4Prep from a tool that answers “*which universities fit me?*” into a program that teaches students “*how do I actually apply?*”

Internal working document • 30 July 2026 • Audience: founder / self • Status: proposal, not committed scope

Add a **Learning Portal** to 4Prep: a structured course of short video lessons that walks an international student through the entire US application, from “is this even possible for me” to the visa interview. Each module ends with **homework the student uploads** — a university shortlist, an essay draft, a budget sheet — which is reviewed and fed back.

The premise: a student who has never seen a US application does not need a better search engine. They need to be taught. The portal is the teaching layer the current product is missing.

1 • Why this belongs in 4Prep

The app today does one thing well: a student enters a profile and gets ranked universities with an explainable fit score and sourced costs. That answers a *question*. It does not carry anyone through a *process*.

For our user — a 17-year-old whose family has never done this, whose school may have no counselor, and who is on a phone — the ranked list is the easy part. The hard part is the twelve months after it: tests, transcripts, essays, recommendations, aid forms, deadlines, the I-20, the visa. Right now they leave the product to figure that out, and mostly they don't.

Three reasons this is the right next thing

- 1 **It converts a lookup into a relationship.** A search tool is visited two or three times. A ten-module course with homework is visited weekly for months. That is the difference between a utility and a product people pay for.
- 2 **Homework is the intake flow, taught.** The Module 1 assignment is a university shortlist — that's the saved plan. Module 3's is transcripts and grades — that's the academic profile. Module 7's is the family budget — that's the financial input. Instead of a cold form the student abandons, the profile gets built as a by-product of learning, one graded piece at a time, and every fit score gets sharper as they go.
- 3 **It fits the honesty positioning.** The whole product is built on never inventing a number. A curriculum is the natural extension: we're not just showing sourced facts, we're explaining what they mean. The same discipline applies — every hard figure in a lesson links to its official source and carries a verification date.

2 • What the student experiences

A new user picks a **track** based on where they are (“I'm 2 years out” / “I apply this year” / “I have offers, now what”). The track is a sequence of modules. Each module is:

- **4–6 video lessons**, each 6–10 minutes, watchable on a phone, with a full text transcript and an audio-only option for low-bandwidth connections.
- **One downloadable template** — a shortlist spreadsheet, an activity-list format, an essay outline, a budget worksheet.
- **One homework assignment** the student completes and uploads.
- **Feedback** on that homework before the next module unlocks.

Progress is visible: a track overview showing which modules are done, which homework is submitted, which is awaiting feedback, and what's next. Completing a module writes real data into the student's 4Prep profile and updates their pathway.

THE CORE LOOP

Watch (6–10 min) → **do** (a real artifact, not a quiz) → **get feedback** → **profile updates** → **next module unlocks**. The unit of value is the artifact the student now owns — a finished shortlist, a finished essay — not the minutes watched.

3 • The curriculum

Ten modules, ordered as the application year actually runs. Written for an international applicant with no family knowledge of the US system.

#	MODULE	WHAT IT TEACHES	HOMEWORK (UPLOADED)
0	Is this possible for me?	How US pricing really works: sticker price vs net price, why aid exists, what the year looks like month by month	Timeline worksheet: your dates, working backward from application deadlines
1	Building your list	Types of institution, need-blind vs need-aware for internationals, reach/match/likely, why the community-college transfer path is real	A shortlist with a net-cost column and a reason for each entry
2	English tests	TOEFL vs IELTS vs Duolingo — who accepts what, when to sit it, what score you actually need, how to prepare	Test plan: which test, which date, target score, registration confirmed
3	Grades & transcripts	Translating your national system into something a US reader understands, credential evaluation, course rigor, predicted grades	Transcript pack: translated grades, school profile, subject list
4	Activities	How US admissions reads extracurriculars, why depth beats breadth, describing work and family responsibility honestly	Activity list in the standard format, ranked by significance
5	The main essay	What a personal statement is and isn't, finding a real subject, the failure modes international applicants fall into most	Full first draft
6	Supplements & "why us"	Researching a specific university properly, writing short answers, reusing material without sounding recycled	Two supplement drafts for two shortlist universities
7	Recommendations	Who to ask and how, what a US reader expects from a teacher letter, what to do when your school has no counselor	Recommender plan plus the brief you'll give each one
8	Money	Institutional aid forms for internationals, merit scholarships, external scholarships, and the financial certification you must document	Family budget sheet plus an aid-form checklist per university
9	Submitting	Application platform mechanics, early vs regular rounds, fee waivers, portals, what happens after you press send	Submission tracker: every university, round, deadline, status
10	After the decision	Comparing offers on net cost, asking for a review of aid, the enrollment document, visa application and interview, pre-departure	Offer comparison and decision memo

CONTENT-STALENESS RULE

Deadlines, test formats, fees, and visa procedures change every year. **No hard number, date, or fee goes into a video.** Videos teach the concept and the reasoning; every figure lives in a linked fact sheet with a source link and a “last verified” date, updatable without re-recording. This is the same rule the catalogue already follows — and it's what keeps the course from rotting after one admissions cycle.

4 • The homework system

Homework is the part that makes this a program rather than a playlist — and it is the hardest part to build well. Three kinds of assignment, deliberately, because they cost very different amounts to review:

TYPE	EXAMPLE	HOW IT'S REVIEWED	COST TO SERVE
Structured	Shortlist, test plan, budget sheet, submission tracker	Automatic. Fields are validated against our own catalogue — we already know the real costs and requirements, so we can tell a student their list has no financially reachable option	Near zero
Checklist	Registration confirmed, recommender asked, documents collected	Self-confirmed, with reminders and a nudge if a deadline is approaching	Near zero
Open artifact	Essay drafts, activity list, decision memo	AI first pass against a published rubric, grounded in that module's material; human review as a limited or paid tier	High

The structured assignments are where the leverage is, and they're the ones nobody else can do — **generic advice content can't check your homework against a sourced database of real university costs.** Build those first. Essay review is the expensive, unbounded one; it should be scoped carefully and probably gated behind the paid tier from day one rather than added to it later.

DESIGN NOTE ON FEEDBACK

Feedback must obey the same trust hierarchy as the counselor: **verified** (checked against our sourced data), **guidance** (general advice, clearly marked as such), and **we won't guess**. AI essay feedback is guidance and must never be dressed up as an admissions verdict. Nothing in the portal should imply we can predict an admission outcome.

5 • What has to be built

Screens

- Track picker / course home with progress
- Module page — lessons, template, assignment
- Lesson player — video, transcript, resources
- Assignment page — brief, rubric, upload
- Submission & feedback view
- Admin review queue (internal)

Data

- tracks, modules, lessons
- assignments (with rubric)
- submissions, submission_files
- feedback, progress
- Owner-only access on everything student-written
- Write-back hooks into profile & saved plans

The decisions that actually matter

- **Video hosting is a buy, not a build.** Use a managed streaming service. Self-hosting video is a trap.
- **Bandwidth is a first-class constraint.** Our student is on a phone, possibly on mobile data, possibly on a slow connection. Every lesson needs a low-bitrate rendition, a downloadable transcript, and an audio-only mode. A course that only works on good wifi excludes exactly the students we're for.
- **File uploads need real limits.** Type allowlist, size cap, owner-only storage policies, and a deletion path — the privacy page already commits us to this and it isn't finished yet.
- **Language.** English base with subtitle tracks. Subtitles are cheap and enormously widen reach; dubbing is not.
- **Accessibility carries over.** Mobile-first at 375px, WCAG AA, 44px touch targets — same as the rest of the app.

6 • Rollout

PHASE	SCOPE	PURPOSE / GATE TO THE NEXT PHASE
0 • Paper pilot	Module 1 only. No video — a written lesson, the shortlist template, and manual feedback given by hand	Find out whether students finish it at all. If they won't complete one written module with a template, they will not complete ten with video. <i>Cheap, and the only honest way to test the premise.</i>
1 • Minimum course	Modules 0–2 with real video, upload, and automatic feedback on structured assignments	Prove the loop end to end and measure completion per module
2 • Full track	All ten modules, progress tracking, profile write-back, AI feedback on open artifacts	A complete product a student can be charged for
3 • Cohorts	Start dates, shared deadlines, peer review, live sessions	Completion rates; deadlines and other people are what make courses get finished

SEQUENCING AGAINST THE SOFT LAUNCH

The current commitment is a twelve-week soft launch running to mid-October, at roughly twenty hours a week, and the core app is not live yet — no public deployment, the counselor endpoint isn't deployed, and the US catalogue migration hasn't been done. **The portal must not compete with that.** Phase 0 is the only piece that belongs inside the soft-launch window, and only because it costs almost nothing: a written lesson, a spreadsheet template, and feedback given by hand to a handful of pilot students. Everything from Phase 1 onward is post-launch work.

7 • Risks, honestly

RISK	WHY IT'S SERIOUS	WHAT REDUCES IT
Content production is the real cost	Forty-plus finished lessons — scripted, recorded, edited, captioned — is a large body of work, and it's founder time that can't be delegated to code. This, not engineering, is what determines whether the portal ships	Build depth-first: one complete, excellent module before ten mediocre ones. Text-first in Phase 0 to validate before any recording
Nobody finishes online courses	Self-paced course completion is notoriously poor. A portal nobody finishes is worse than nothing — it makes the product feel abandoned	Short lessons, homework as the unit of value, cohort deadlines in Phase 3, and honest measurement from Phase 0
Free content already exists	Much of this is on YouTube for nothing, some of it good	The differentiator isn't the explanation — it's that homework is checked against our sourced catalogue and writes back to a personalized pathway. Nobody else can grade your shortlist against real net costs
It goes stale	An out-of-date course on deadlines and visas is actively harmful, and directly contradicts the product's central promise	The no-numbers-in-video rule, with all figures in dated, sourced, updatable fact sheets
Scope creep	A learning platform is a second product. It has its own admin tooling, review queue, and support burden	Treat every phase gate as a real gate. Phase 0 must produce evidence before Phase 1 is funded with time

8 • Open questions

- **Is this the paid tier?** The most natural business model is: catalogue and fit scores free, portal paid. That needs deciding early because it shapes what goes behind the login and how feedback is scoped.
- **How much human review, and by whom?** Essay feedback is the most valuable and least scalable part. Founder-reviewed for the pilot cohort is fine; it doesn't survive growth.
- **One track or several?** A student two years out and a student with offers in hand need very different things. Starting with one track — the application-year track — is probably right.
- **Who is the teacher on camera?** Credibility matters enormously here. An anonymous voiceover is weaker than a named person with a real background in admissions.
- **What counts as success in Phase 0?** Set the completion threshold before running the pilot, not after.

THE ONE-SENTENCE VERSION

4Prep already knows what a student should do; the Learning Portal teaches them how to do it, and checks their work against the same sourced data the recommendations are built on. Prove students will finish one written module before recording a single video.

4Prep.ai — Learning Portal concept note. Internal planning document; figures and timings are proposals, not commitments. No figures in this document are drawn from the sourced catalogue.